Braj poets in the regional courts began to experiment with the vernacular in innovative ways in the late sixteenth century using Persian imagery and Sanskrit classicism—these poetic forms would become immensely popular and widespread by the early seventeenth century. One of the reasons for the efflorescence of this vernacular poetry was the enthusiastic patronage by the Mughals. This patronage has been almost completely overlooked because Mughal chroniclers themselves took note of Persian writings over all other languages and so the presumption that Hindi writing was predominantly Hindu became largely accepted. But Alison Busch describes this Mughal patronage as ‘early, copious and critical to the consolidation of Hindi’s courtly style’. The Braj dialect of Brindavan and Mathura, driven by the Vaishnava Bhakti movements of the late sixteenth century, would have been familiar to the Mughal court due to the physical proximity of Fatehpur Sikri and the extensive patronage of these towns not only by the emperor but by his family and courtiers as well. These enormously popular poems in Braj would have certainly not been unknown to Akbar, who was not only familiar with Braj, but according to Abu’l Fazl even composed the occasional verse in the language. Harkha Bai herself had a profound interest in the region as did her entire family and, as for Salim, Braj was his mother tongue. We hear of courtiers composing in Braj, or Hindi, too—Birbal, Todar Mal, Faizi, and, most famously, Abdur Rahim.

Of the Braj poets known to be associated with the Mughal court the most well-known was Gang. Later equated alongside Tulsidas as one of two sardars among Braj poets, Gang wrote poetry for Mughal patrons including Akbar, Abdur Rahim and his sons, Prince Daniyal, Raja Man Singh, and Birbal.

Other significant works of Hindi kavya to be produced at a mansabdar’s court were by the poet Keshavdas Misra in Orchha. Orchha had become subsumed into the Mughal Empire in the 1570s when Raja Madhukar Shah was defeated relatively easily and his sons, including one Ratnasena, were sent to serve at the Mughal court. These incontrovertible facts were, however, quite summarily dismissed and using virtuoso technical skill and verbal calisthenics in Brajbhasha the poet Keshavdas Misra created for his patrons a much more pleasing world in terms of martial values demonstrated. In the *Ratnabhavani,* written soon after Orchha’s capitulation in the 1570s, the Mughals are roundly censored and abused as being ‘Mlecchas’, ‘Turks’ and ‘Pathans’ whereas Prince Ratnasena is compared to